

boats and attack helicopters, it imposed a curfew on the local population and limited Viet Cong movements, securing waterways and preventing attacks on regional cities.

In 1967, the newly formed Mobile Riverine Force (MRF) extended the Navy's capabilities by pairing Army infantry with Navy armored assault boats. The initial operation in the Rung Sat Special Zone—a vast area of mangrove forest south of Saigon—involved a “hammer-and-anvil” attack in which riverine infantry landed to drive Viet Cong forces toward a second attack force delivered by helicopter. The operation helped secure provincial capitals and prevented the Viet Cong from mining water approaches to Saigon.



Riverine operation

The crew aboard an inshore patrol craft (PCF), known as a swift boat, fire at Viet Cong positions in a search-and-destroy mission along the Duong Keo River on the Ca Mau Peninsula in April 1969. Riverine assault craft were heavily armed and armored.

Fatal accidents

Navy personnel engaged in riverine operations faced many of the same hardships and threats suffered by ground troops engaged in search-and-destroy operations farther north. However, for sailors in the Seventh Fleet, the threat of accident—fires, helicopter crashes, collisions, explosions, and errors launching aircraft—exceeded the risk of injury from attack. The heaviest Navy casualties due to enemy action occurred in 1968, when Viet Cong divers detonated two mines alongside the USS *Westchester County*, killing 25 sailors. In 1967, the Navy's deadliest accident of the war resulted from the discharge of a Zuni rocket on the USS *Forrestal* that caused a chain of explosions that killed 131 sailors and injured 160 more.